Q+A

"WE'RE ALL NOAH NOW"

In his new book, *Eden*, Devdutt Pattanaik explores Jewish, Christian and Islamic lore from a uniquely Indian perspective. The results are riveting

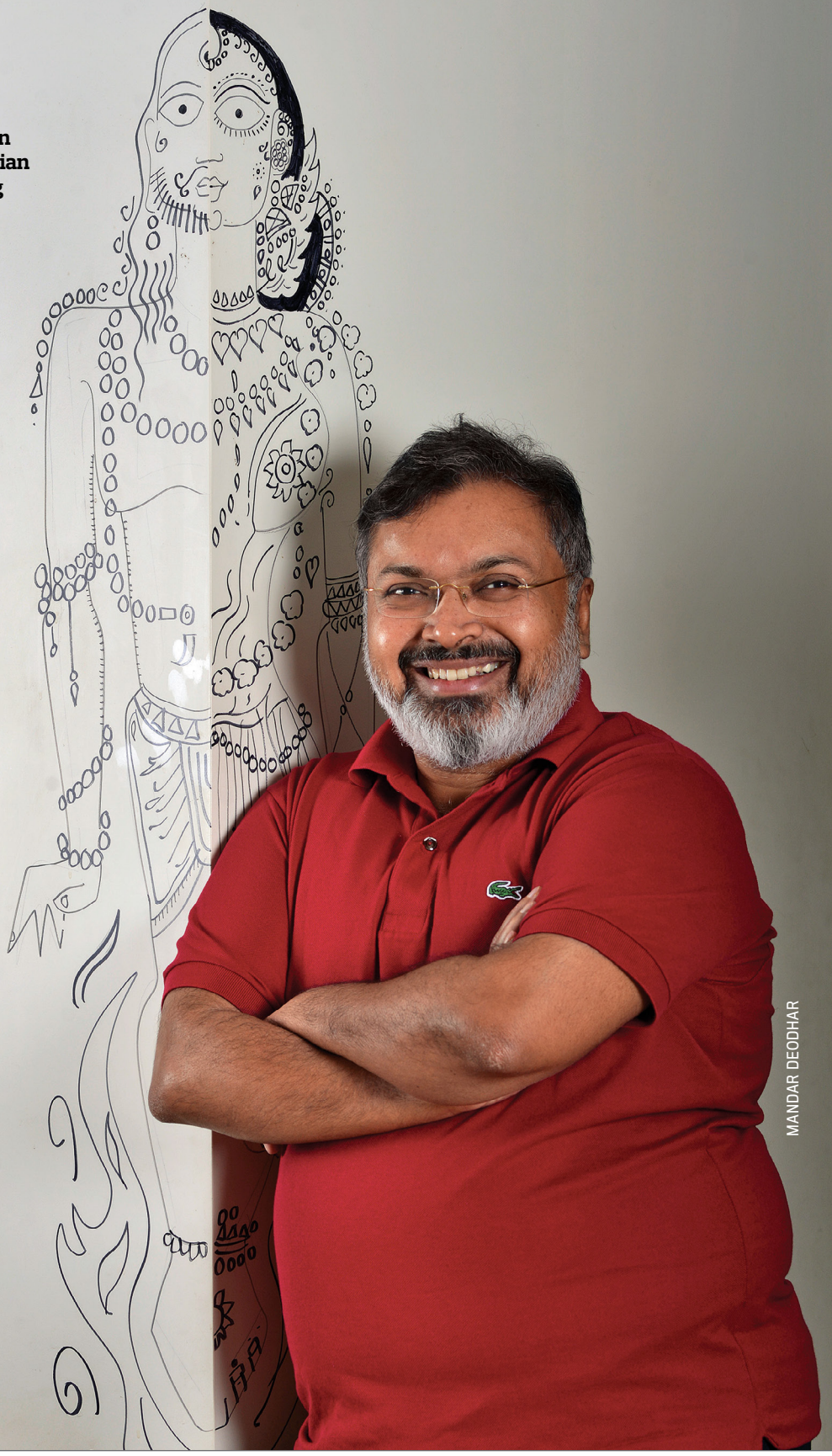
Q. When looking at Abrahamic myths through an Indian lens, how did you avoid overt comparisons?
When you see two things, you will compare and contrast. But I don't think comparison necessarily creates a hierarchy. I never say one is better than the other. I think sometimes people's minds are narrow. I aim to expand the mind, so people start accommodating more than one idea simultaneously.

Q. How hard was illustrating this book?
It has been a dream of mine to illustrate biblical stories with an Indian touch ever since I saw Sassanian paintings of Islamic lore, Ottoman miniatures and those biblical drawings from Ethiopia. I would invariably ask myself—how would the Tower of Babel look if an Indian had drawn it?

Q. What role do myths and folklore play in a Covid world?
Take the story of Noah, for example. He is on this boat in the middle of a flood, hoping that all the animals on his ark survive. Similarly, us humans, locked in our homes, waiting for Covid to retreat, are all Noahs, too. The human metaphor has a power to connect.

Q. Are ancient myths naturally relevant to the 21st century, or is it the task of the mythologist to place them in context?
All stories are trying to satisfy a human need. Mythological stories are particularly powerful since they always talk in terms which secular narratives don't—origins of the world, end of the world, purpose of life. The story of the Big Bang doesn't energise you. It just says that you're a particle. Scientists cannot explain things like jealousy, anger and misery. Stories do that.

—with Shreevatsa Nevatia



MANDAR DEODHAR